

# 5 Tips for Making a Good Impression — Virtually

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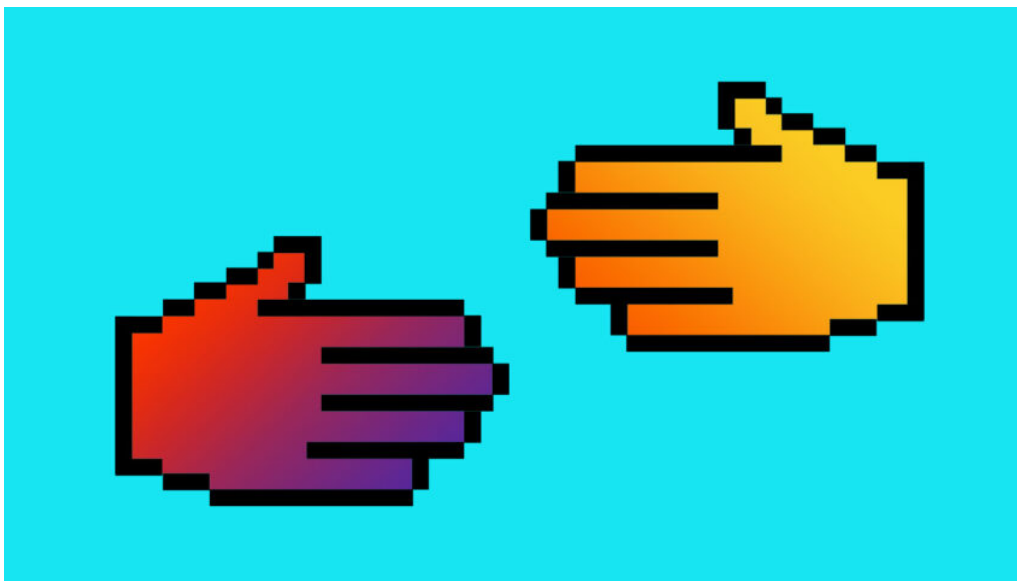
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by

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Summary.

People tend to behave more aggressively in virtual interactions

- A lack of in-person interactions means our brains are getting fewer signals to practice self-restraint, making more room for impulsive behavior.
- Here are five ways to be more mindful about the virtual impression you're making.

As millions of people around the world have recently moved from office to teleworking environments, due to social-distancing measures required by the Covid-19 crisis, many will be leading or joining virtual teams. In my research, I've identified what I call the "Big 5 E-communication Whammies" — behavioral changes associated with non-face-to-face interactions that can lead to negative consequences ranging from hurt feelings to lost jobs. In the current scenario, there is one I'd like to especially call out.

**What is the "Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde" E-communication Whammy?**

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The “Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde” whammy, based on the classic Robert Louis Stevenson novel about a physician with a dark alter-ego, refers to people’s tendency to behave in a more negative, aggressive way online versus in-person. In many cases, they unleash their inner “Mr. or Ms. Hyde” without realizing it.

Why does this happen?

Think of it this way: Real-time, face-to-face interaction is the connective glue of collaboration in most businesses. So when we lose the physical-presence component of professional interactions, it’s like removing the load-bearing walls that have invisibly supported most of our work relationships.

People generally behave differently in virtual interactions — including email and other web-based technologies — and their behavior sways toward the more negative, aggressive end of the spectrum. From a neuroscience perspective, the lack of real-time visual feedback changes signals the brain sends, likely leading to lack of restraint and impulsive behavior — what’s known as the “online disinhibition effect.”

In general, social disinhibition refers to a willingness to behave in a way you might not normally. That’s much more likely to happen in virtual interaction.

Here are several research-based examples of online disinhibition, or the inner Hyde at work:

- **Feedback:** People deliver harsher feedback virtually than in-person, such as for performance reviews.
- **Threats:** People are more likely to make threats by email versus face-to-face or by phone.
- **Interpretation:** People are more likely to perceive positive virtual messages as neutral, and neutral communications as negative — known as the “negativity effect.” This can also help explain the well-documented phenomenon of “irony poisoning”: The more time people spend online, the less able they are to discern when someone is being facetious.
- **Conflict:** Conflict in virtual teams is more likely to escalate and to affect their performance than for in-person teams.
- **Deception:** One study showed that people interacting online lied 90% of the time, even when they knew interaction partners would be informed of the deception.

## How to Improve Your Virtual Interactions

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Anyone moving from largely in person to mostly virtual interactions is at risk for the Mr. Hyde whammy. However, the good news is that you can mind your Hyde effectively. Here are five tips to foster positive virtual interactions.

**Turn on your webcam for meetings:** Most people I’ve surveyed since social distancing became widespread have admitted they don’t use their webcams. In my modules on “virtual teams,” I advise my business professionals to use their camera because my

research reveals that when people humanize the interaction, more trust and cooperation develops. However, people are very resistant: One senior leader said, “I don’t want people to see my bedhead and cow-print pajamas!” I urge you to turn on your camera because 1) you’re unlikely to be judged for how you look and 2) just seeing someone’s face leads to brain changes fostering better interactions.

**Maximize the video-chat screen and don’t multitask:** If you’re on a video meeting, resist the urge to minimize the screen and open another program or document. Instead, practice “mutual gazing” by maintaining eye contact with the speaker. That increases oxytocin, the trust-and-bonding hormone.

**Place a mirror on your desk:** Look at it while you’re having a conversation with a colleague or team member. People who had to communicate virtually with a mirror present behaved in a more diplomatic, constructive fashion. Looking at your own image on-screen while on a video call may also serve this purpose.

**Take five minutes to recharge:** Humans have a specific reserve of energy for making decisions and behaving judiciously. Once that reserve is used, we’re more likely to become cognitively depleted, leading to more negative behavior. Break the cycle by taking a brief break, eating, or exercising before a virtual meeting, or by breaking up longer meeting into shorter ones.

**Schmooze or lose:** Virtual teams tend to get right down to business and skip the human factor, whether that’s by email or virtual conference. But research shows that even five minutes of non-business-related conversation can set the team on a much more positive, productive course.